

From Objective Character Motivation to Learners’ Subjective Reconstruction

A Pilot Study on Conceptual Mapping in the Rén Component Family among Spanish-Speaking Learners of Chinese

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Is the Rén component family visually transparent, or cognitively reconstructible?

The Rén component family is historically motivated by the graphic representation of the human figure, but this motivation is not necessarily perceived directly by Spanish-speaking learners.

Theoretical background and research problem

Character motivation. The Rén component family is explained through character structure, etymology, and form–meaning relations.

Conceptual mapping. Learners map graphic cues onto prior knowledge, schemas, and associations.

Research problem. Objective motivation does not automatically become learner-perceived motivation.

Pilot study

- **Participants:** 9 Spanish-speaking beginner learners of Chinese
- **Task:** open-ended character-form interpretation
- **Focus:** 人 and its component family
- **Data:** exploratory questionnaire responses
- **Analysis:** inductive coding

Results: learner interpretations across the Rén component family

Morphological note: 人 → 亻 from pictographic form to person-related component and semantic radical

象形 Pictographs 人

Perceptual level: the human figure is not fully transparent.

Explanatory level: learners may construct interpretations that approach the traditional pictographic rationale.

Es como una personita
caminando.



“It’s like a little person walking.”

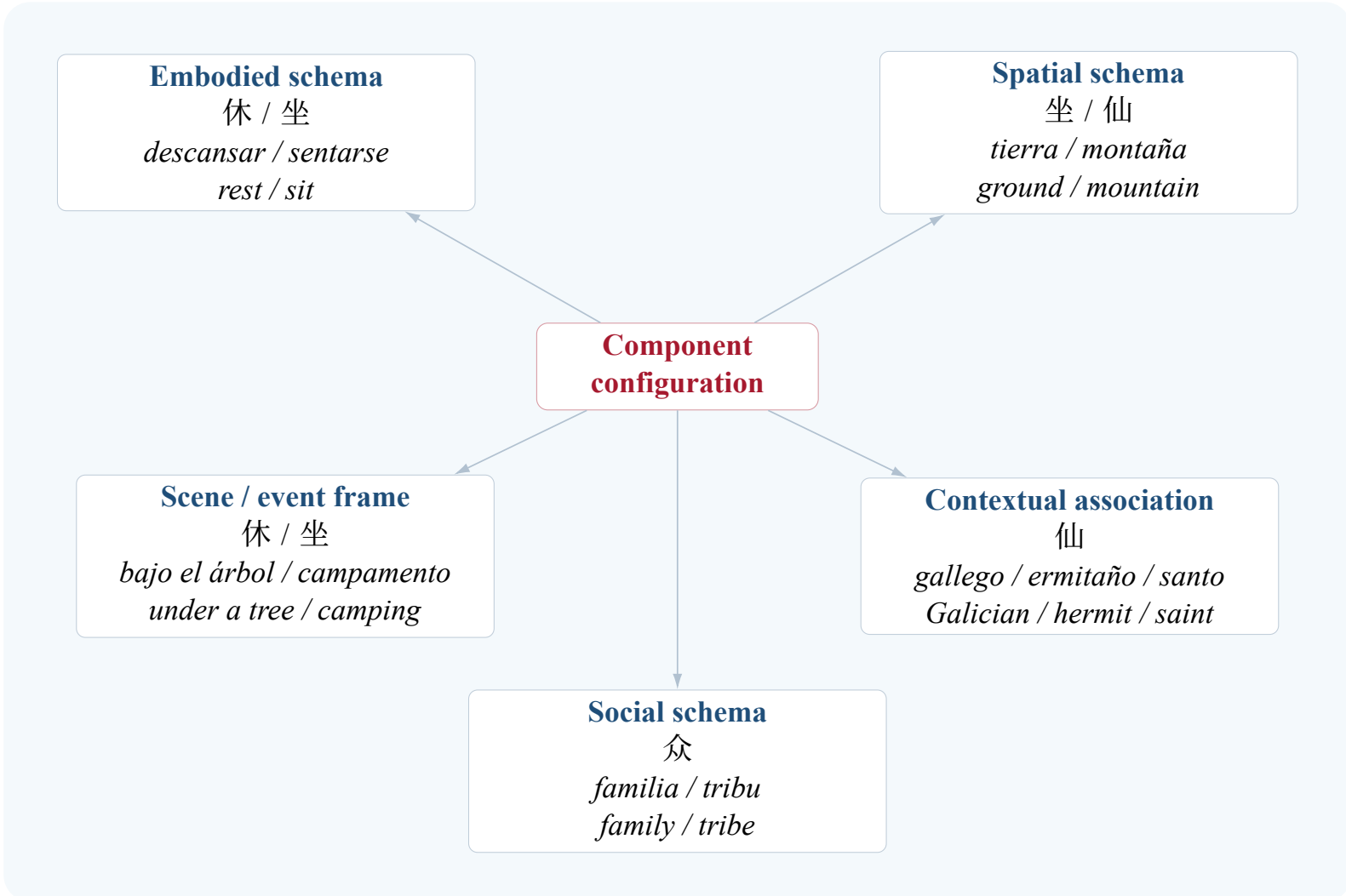
Diría que parece una montaña o
el tejado de una casa.

“I would say it looks like a mountain or the roof of a house.”

会意 Associative compounds 休 / 仙 / 坐 / 众

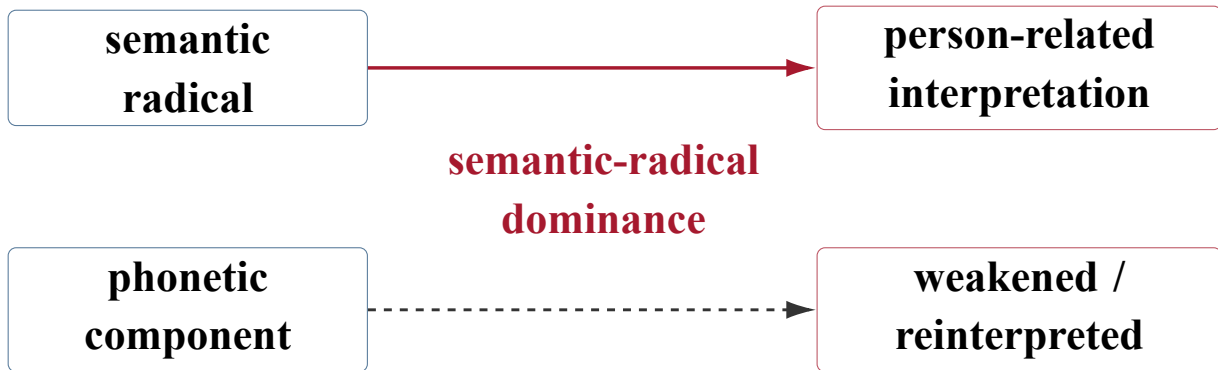
Key pattern: component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames that learners integrate into subjective rationales.

Schema / frame activation



Selected responses show how component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames.

形声 Phono-semantic compounds 你 / 什 / 伙



nueve llamada otra
pirómanos hoguera fuego
buena
person
gemelos divina bombero
cocinero voluntariosa
inquieto acompaña
diez tú pronombre
él 10 entusiasta inmortal

In characters with 亻, persona emerges as the dominant learner association.

Not directly transparent, but cognitively reconstructible

Objective motivation ≠ learner interpretation

Learners reconstruct the Rén component family by mapping graphic cues onto learner knowledge and integrating them into subjective rationales.

Conceptual mapping model

Shared abstract structure:
salient person-related cue + co-present element

Interpretable relation / scene / category

Character-form space

人 亻 木 山
休 仙 坐 众
你 什 伙

graphic, componential,
and phono-semantic cues

Conceptual mappings

Learner knowledge space

visual analogy
embodied–spatial schemas
social–cultural knowledge
lexical categories
co-component reinterpretation

Cognitive operations

Cue uptake
Association activation
Integrative mapping

Emergent learner-constructed subjective rationale

Pictographs: human figure or competing visual analogy
Associative compounds: embodied, spatial, social, and contextual rationales
Phono-semantic compounds: semantic-radical dominance (亻); phonetic component weakened or reinterpreted

Mechanism, implications and supplement

Mechanism

1. **Non-automatic transparency** — character motivation ≠ learner-perceived motivation
2. **Cue-triggered reconstruction** — whole forms, components, and radicals as triggers
3. **Selective integration** — graphic cues integrated with embodied, spatial, social, and cultural schemas

Teaching implications

- **Etymology is not self-evident** — use learner rationales as a bridge to character-structure explanation
- **Learner rationales as scaffolding** — reveal how graphic form connects with meaning
- **From association to structure** — start from rationales; guard against arbitrary interpretation

Deviations reveal cognitive strategy selection.

Pedagogy should use learner-constructed rationales as scaffolds to make character structure and form–meaning relations explicit.

References

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PDF, references and contact